position and authority of the Corps Commander. However, on balance, we felt that it would be an advantage to have the JS (East Asia) as part of our delegation. Thereafter, starting from the sixth round onwards, Naveen was always there and provided the much-needed institutional continuity that had been lacking earlier.[16] The Corps Commander designate Lt Gen PGK Menon, who was to take over the Corps the next month, also participated to get a feel of the discussions that he would have to take forward.[17]

The monsoon session of the Parliament was scheduled to commence from 14 September. It was the first time that the Parliament would be in session since the face-off had begun in mid-May. A lot had been said and written on it, with the Opposition baying for blood. It was evident that a statement would have to be made in Parliament, to quell unwanted speculation. But who should make the statement? The MEA in the form of the EAM or the MoD in the form of the RM? The MEA was of the view that it should be the EAM as it involved another country and that had been the norm even during earlier stand-offs at Depsang and Chumar. However, in light of the fact that the casualties had been suffered by the Army and the counter-moves of end-August 2020 were also carried out by the Army, it was decided that it should be the RM who ought to give the statement. We got down to preparing a draft statement for the RM. We felt it had to be factual, with no hyperbole, yet reassuring. The RM though, wanted it to be a little stronger. He said it must have passages that arouse our spirit of nationalism and which should get the MPs across party lines 'thumping the tables' in a show of solidarity. We had to get everything just right, leaving no room for any blowback. Proceedings of the Parliament are on record and any mis-statement could backfire at a later date. We had to anticipate any awkward questions that

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